

A Series to Forget

Rarely has India vs Australia been so ugly with mismatched teams, bad blood and allegations of racism

■ By Sharda Ugra

Can you honestly remember the last time when the rational wanted an India vs Australia series to end? So that everybody could go home and there would be peace and quiet again? Since 2001, India vs Australia has been razor's edge cricket, teams churned through a spin cycle of glory, misery and redemption in a few hours.

In utter contrast, this wretched thing we have just endured—seven mongrel ODIs—has turned India vs Australia into a footpath fist-fight. It had its moments, its result was predictable but all you can remember is the ugliness.

Before Sreesanth grabbed the headlines with an unseemly temper tantrum, there was the young tykes vs aged warriors debate. By the time Andrew Symonds said he had been racially taunted, nothing could rescue the series. Least of all the cricket played by India.

The Symonds incident rightly raised outrage in Australia because their crowds are often ticked off for bad behaviour. The lack of response from Indian officialdom has infuriated Australia but there's a good chance the BCCI must be wondering where to begin.

According to some reports, the Baroda crowd were heckling Symonds for being Symonds and not, as claimed, the only "black" player on the Aussie team; local officials maintain the crowd was shouting variations of "*Ganpati Bappa Morya*". Yes, Indian cricket crowds can be extremely offensive, their behaviour crossing over from lively to objectionable very quickly. Their racist—or communal, regional or personal—abuse though is

usually verbal and targeted equally at visiting and home players. The second incident of racial taunting, in Nagpur, was an opportunity lost to make an example. The TV cameraman in Nagpur, who spotted a man imitating a monkey to rile Symonds, should have filmed the spectator and got the feed aired. It would have had the pressure of TV bear down on local authorities to have the spectator ejected mid-match. Airing that feed repeatedly would have given potential jokers the message. But all

overall meaninglessness when not backed up by sharp cricket. India didn't win the World T20 because they could match every "f*** you" with "f*** you too." They won because they played intense cricket for 40 overs.

Over 100 overs, against the masters of the game, things have been very different—and the Indian management knew it would be, even as they left Johannesburg for their return home. Much was made of the injection of youth versus the arthritic creakiness of

the old. But against the toughest competition in world cricket, it was the ancient mariners who had the answers and who turned in the most consistent performances.

Yes, they cannot play forever and they will not play in the 2011 World Cup and India must plan for the future and it is better to lose with young players than old ones. All very fine. This series though was the ideal opportunity for any one of the young top order batsmen to make a compelling case, to compel push to come to shove for the old boys on the basis of more than just his birth certificate.

The only other lasting echo from this miserable series has come from Andrew Symonds: both from his log-like bat and

from his palpable, steaming envy over the rewards given to the Indian World T20 team. Two World Cups and a Champions Trophy later, Symonds must feel severely short-changed by his country and his people to go on and on about it. But there's a way Cricket Australia could make it up to him: by outsourcing their victory celebrations to the BCCI.



AP PHOTO/GAUTAM SINGH

Australia showed that if not backed up by sharp cricket, chest thumping is meaningless.

we have now is a did-not-did-too scenario and words, words, words.

Something India's youthful World T20 team should have been wary of. At the World T20, M.S. Dhoni declared that if anyone wanted a "verbal war", with the Indians "we are ready for it—because you don't need any talent for that." Dhoni understands the token value of chest thumping but also its